



1931–2004 · American sociologist and communication theorist.

"Adoption is a social process, not a switch."

THE WHY THAT DROVE THE WORK

Rogers asked why some innovations spread rapidly while others, equally good, fail — and concluded that adoption is a social process, not a technical inevitability.

INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Synthesising hundreds of studies, he built a general theory of how innovations diffuse through a population over time, defining adopter categories from innovators to laggards.

FRAMEWORKS ANCHORED IN THIS COURSE

He anchors the Diffusion S-Curve in Unit 2, the model of how AI and other innovations are adopted in stages.

HOW THE IDEAS OPERATIONALISE

His theory operationalises as tailoring strategy to the next adopter group and attending to an innovation's perceived attributes (relative advantage, compatibility, complexity, trialability, observability).

LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUE

The model can underweight power, inequality and the active shaping of diffusion by firms, and adopter categories are idealised.

ENDURING IMPACT

Diffusion of Innovations is among the most cited works in the social sciences, underpinning marketing, public health and technology strategy.

ON THE SAME PANEL (UNIT 2)

Erik Brynjolfsson · Giant 6

Robert Solow · Giant 7

Eliyahu Goldratt · Giant 9

Dave McClure · Giant 10

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Rogers, E.M. (1962) Diffusion of Innovations. New York: Free Press.

Rogers, E.M. (2003) Diffusion of Innovations. 5th edn. New York: Free Press.